

# ‘Play the game, not the opponent’

This simple mantra by head coach Ajay Sharma became the **cornerstone** of J&K’s evolution from underdog to giant-slayer.

**Ajay Sharma**

**M**ithun Manhas (BCCI President), the architect of Jammu and Kashmir’s rise as a force in domestic cricket, had debuted under my captaincy and believed I could deliver. The players were doing well with the white ball, but they needed someone to shine with the red ball. I insisted they adopt a winning approach with a changed mindset. They had been participating, not looking to win. I changed that. J&K would no longer be taken for granted.

I was in Thailand on holiday when Mithun called me (2022) and convinced me to apply. Honestly, I was reluctant because I was coaching the Delhi Under-19 team at Rohan Jaitley’s request. I was looking for a promotion in Delhi, but it didn’t happen. I applied for the J&K job just before the deadline. I was apprehensive, but on Mithun’s word, I took up the assignment. I joined the Jammu & Kashmir Cricket Association (with voting rights) after giving up my membership of the Delhi and District Cricket Association. I was determined to move on.

It was a hard grind. With basic facilities, we faced the challenge of providing the boys with meaningful infrastructure. There was a process followed by the formation of a sub-committee. Jay Shah (then BCCI Secretary) monitored the process and provided funding. I was given absolute power to select the team, with transparency in the process.

We organised red-soil pitches to prepare for the bounce we encounter when competing outside the state. It was a handicap since we have only two grounds (Science College, Jammu, and the Sher-e-Kashmir Stadium). We started playing in tournaments like the Buchi Babu (in Chennai) and the JP Atray (in Chandigarh). I knew we would be on the road for eight months, and I prepared the boys for it. We got the necessary exposure and also invited teams to keep the preparations going.

Playing the semifinals of the Buchi Babu last year was a

boost. We started believing in ourselves. The batters applied themselves and gained toughness and physical fitness. The one-run loss in the Ranji Trophy 2025 quarterfinal was a lesson. The team realised the importance of one run. Shoulders did not drop. We had a committed team with several matchwinners.

Auqib Nabi and Abdul Samad are precocious talents. I have not seen a bowler like Nabi. We brought in Paras Dogra to lead the team. His father (cricketer Kultar) was my friend. Dogra brought professionalism. We were on a mission now. Bowling coach P. Krishnakumar and fielding coach Dishant Yagnik made the support staff a great force. Discipline was never compromised.

We were inspired by the team’s brilliant performances — beating Baroda, Mumbai, Delhi, Madhya Pradesh and Karnataka (in their own dens). The team developed solid confidence. This season, we lost to Mumbai at home. On a seaming pitch, their left-arm spinner (Shams Mulani) took seven wickets. Otherwise, we were beating big teams without a star.

We had to develop the habit of winning, one game at a time. Play the game, not the opponent. We had the talent to do it. My challenge initially was remembering their names. It took time to recognise them. I had to paste their photos on plain paper and memorise them. But I did it. I